

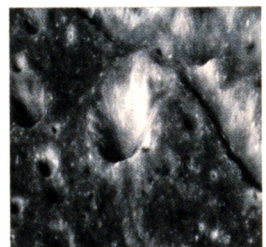


CHANDRAYAN (LEFT) WAS LAUNCHED LAST YEAR; (BELOW) A LUNAR IMAGE FROM THE SPACECRAFT

DELHI | Dark Side of the Moon

India's first moon mission Chandrayaan-1 came to an abrupt end on August 29 after orbiting the lunar surface for 312 days, half its expected lifespan. Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has set up a team to investigate its premature termination. But initial analysis indicates that a malfunctioning spacecraft star sensor, a device to track the craft's orientation, overheated due to the sun's radiation, blowing up the power units and rendering communication with the craft impossible. Despite the setback, ISRO Chairman G. Madhavan Nair stated that the Rs 386-crore moon mission had achieved "95 per cent of its objectives" beaming down a large volume of data, including 70,000 images. The craft made India join a clutch of five nations that have sent up lunar missions. The October 2008 launch carried 11 payloads, six of them for other entities including NASA, Bulgaria and Europe. Probably the most affected was a detailed survey of the lunar surface to produce a three-dimensional topographic map that included its chemical characteristics. ISRO, though, is already looking ahead with Nair—who became the first Asian to become president of the International Academy of Astronautics—stating that Chandrayaan-2 is on track for a 2013 launch. He is optimistic of ISRO sending a spacecraft to Mars soon after. For ISRO, the moon is not the limit.

by Stephen David



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thousand images of the moon were beamed back to earth by Chandrayan-1 in 10 months.